

The Lewis & Clark Expedition

Put the Corps of Discovery's 1804–1806 journey in order, name the people who made it possible, and ask what it meant for the Native nations along the way.

? Historical challenge

In 1804, President Jefferson sent a team called the Corps of Discovery to explore the huge new land west of the Mississippi River, all the way to the Pacific Ocean. What did they do first, next, and last — and who helped them along the way? Follow the trail and put the journey in order.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Travel the Lewis & Clark Expedition – Expedition by Date (National Park Service)

SECONDARY SOURCE

A day-by-day timeline of the journey from the National Park Service.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What are three events in order from the timeline?
- How long did the whole journey take?

SOURCES 2

Jefferson's Secret Message Regarding the Lewis & Clark Expedition (Library of Congress)

PRIMARY SOURCE

Jefferson's confidential January 1803 message to Congress asking for money to fund the expedition.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did Jefferson want to send the expedition west?
- What does a 'secret message' tell you about the plan?

SOURCES 3

Expedition Timeline (Thomas Jefferson's Monticello)

SECONDARY SOURCE

A timeline and background on the expedition's goals.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What were the expedition's main goals?
- Which goal do you think mattered most?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

Lewis & Clark Expedition

1804–1806

St. Louis to the Pacific Ocean

1 Moment 1

1804 (May 14) — The Corps sets off up the Missouri River near St. Louis.



2 Moment 2

1804–1805 (winter) — The Corps builds Fort Mandan; Sacagawea joins the group.



3 Moment 3

1805 (summer) — The Corps crosses the Rocky Mountains with Shoshone and Nez Perce help.



4 Moment 4

1805 (November) — The Corps reaches the Pacific Ocean and builds Fort Clatsop.



5 Moment 5

1806 (Sept 23) — The Corps returns safely to St. Louis.

Important people / groups

Meriwether Lewis & William Clark
— co-captains

Sacagawea (Lemhi Shoshone) —
interpreter who helped guide and
trade

York — Clark's enslaved man, a
full working member of the Corps

Corps of Discovery — about 45
soldiers and explorers

Mandan, Hidatsa, Shoshone & Nez
Perce nations — hosts who gave
food, directions, and horses

Why did this matter?

The journey mapped a huge new
part of the country, recorded
hundreds of plants, animals, and
Native nations, and opened the
West to more American travel and
settlement.

One question I still have

How did the Native nations along
the trail feel about the strangers
crossing their homelands — and
what happened to those nations
afterward?

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your trail order with a partner. Did you put the moments in the same sequence? Where did you disagree?
- Which moment do you think was the most important turning point of the journey? Why?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The expedition (1804–1806) mapped about 8,000 miles round trip, recorded plants, animals, and Native nations, and strengthened U.S. claims to the West. Sacagawea (Lemhi Shoshone) and York (an enslaved man) were vital members. The Corps could not have succeeded without food, directions, and horses from Native nations.

Common misconceptions

- Lewis and Clark did not 'discover' empty land — Native nations had lived there for thousands of years.
- Sacagawea did not single-handedly guide the whole trip; she interpreted and helped at key moments.
- The expedition did not find an all-water route to the Pacific — no Northwest Passage existed.

Vocabulary

Corps of Discovery, Louisiana Purchase, expedition, interpreter, Northwest Passage, Fort Mandan, Fort Clatsop.

Historical context

Departed near St. Louis May 14, 1804; wintered 1804–05 at Fort Mandan (met Sacagawea); crossed the Rockies in summer 1805 with Shoshone and Nez Perce help; reached the Pacific in Nov. 1805 (Fort Clatsop); returned to St. Louis Sept. 23, 1806.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Tell the story of the expedition in your own words, in order. Use at least three moments from your trail and name at least two people or groups who made the journey possible.